



Rock crystal pendant | This rock crystal heart-shaped pendant, suspended from a gold and blue enamel bow, originates from the 19th century.



Rock crystal brooch | In the 19th century, gold brooches such as this with rock crystal "windows" were commonly used to store a lock of a loved one's hair.



Faceted egg | This full-size rock crystal egg has been faceted with hundreds of perfectly meeting facets in a display of the highest gem-cutting skill.



Rock crystal brooch | Made in 1972 in Birmingham, UK, this 18-karat gold, sapphire, and rock crystal brooch features an unusual abstract design.



Crown facets

White gold setting

Rock crystal ring | In this white gold ring, a dazzling lozenge-shaped, fancy-cut rock crystal gemstone has been cleverly set to protect its sharp points from chipping.



Tourmalated quartz | The material from which this extremely fine Chinese snuff bottle is carved is rock crystal with hundreds of tourmaline needles within it.



Citrine and amethyst | The oval-cut citrine gemstone in the centre of this ornate brooch is surrounded by gold leaves and brilliant-cut amethysts.

Crystal skulls

Ancient mystery or hoax?

In modern culture, skulls cut from quartz have become popular for their alleged mystic qualities. Supposedly ancient Mesoamerican artefacts, none of the examples submitted for scientific testing have so far been authenticated as pre-Columbian. All have shown the marks of 19th-century tools; all are made from a type of quartz found in Madagascar; and many of them also seem to have passed through the hands of the same 19th-century antiques dealer, Eugène Boban.



Carved skull This artefact is made from rock crystal and measures 25cm (10in) in height.